PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Toyota FJ Cruiser

2007–2014 (US) · to 2022 elsewhere · XJ10 · GSJ15 · 1GR-FE 4.0 V6

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Get under it with a hammer and a light**
  Frame rust is the FJ's big weakness in salt-belt states. An IH8MUD member who shopped the Northeast said every truck he looked at had rot around the rear control-arm brackets or had already been patched. Another warned about rust hidden under thick fresh undercoating. Rust Buster's list of FJ repair sections (rail ends, center rails, crossmembers, coil buckets, body mounts) shows where to probe.

- [ ] **Open the hood and look at the inner fenders**
  The engine-bay inner fender aprons on 2007 and some early 2008 trucks could bulge and crack, and Toyota changed the design. Owners on IH8MUD report cracks that never grew and others that went all the way through. Look on both sides behind the headlights and price in a repair if they're split.

- [ ] **Check the rear access doors**
  The front seat-belt retractors are mounted in the rear-hinged access doors, and the door panels can crack after years of being slammed. Toyota recalled 2007–2013 trucks for it (NHTSA 13V098000). Run the VIN for open recalls and look at the inner door panels.

- [ ] **Feel for a clunk when it downshifts**
  A harsh jolt into first after sitting in Drive, as if you'd been rear-ended, is covered by Toyota bulletin T-SB-0046-12 for 2007–2013 FJ Cruisers and Tacomas. Greasing a dry rear driveshaft slip yoke often fixes it. Ask whether the driveshafts have been greased; Toyota calls for it every 5,000 miles on dirt, salt or when towing.

- [ ] **Manual trucks: listen at the clutch**
  A squeak or rattle from the gearbox that stops when you press the clutch is T-SB-0365-10 on 2007–2011 six-speed FJs: updated release bearing, fork support and release cylinder, with the transmission out. Manuals are much rarer than automatics, so expect to search harder.

- [ ] **Test every 4WD mode**
  Shift into 4H and 4L, try the rear locker and A-TRAC, and watch for warning lights that stay on. On automatic trucks the front axle is engaged by an electric disconnect actuator on the front differential; IH8MUD owners say they fail mostly from unsoldered internal contacts or water getting in.

- [ ] **Know which engine you're buying**
  2007–2009 trucks make 239 hp and are rated on premium fuel; the dual VVT-i engine from 2010 makes 259–260 hp on regular. 4×2 automatics exist, so check the transfer-case lever. Trail Teams editions are monotone with blacked-out trim; confirm a claimed edition with the window sticker or a dealer build record.

- [ ] **Clear the smaller recalls too**
  2014 trucks built 7–20 August 2013 need a new intermediate steering shaft (15V081000). Ultimate Editions had front lower ball-joint and lower-arm bolts checked for torque (14V539000). Trucks with the TRD brake kit or Toyota auxiliary driving lamps have their own campaigns.

YEARS TO KNOW

2007	BEWARE	Launch: 239-hp 1GR-FE on premium, six-speed manual (full-time 4WD) or five-speed automatic; 3,200 TRD Special Editions. CarGurus says owners report far more problems with 2007s than any other year, and inner fender aprons on early trucks can bulge and crack. IH8MUD owners add that some builds before February 2007 had a brittle rear ring and pinion
2010	SWEET SPOT	Dual VVT-i 1GR-FE: 259 hp on regular fuel, slightly better economy, and a slightly larger rear diff. CarGurus ties the fender-apron bulge mainly to 2007–09 trucks, so 2010–14 are the years owners usually steer buyers toward

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Rear access-door panels can crack at the seat-belt retractor**
  2007–2013 · NHTSA 13V098000
- ☐ **Intermediate steering shaft weld**
  2014 (built 7–20 August 2013) · NHTSA 15V081000
- ☐ **Trail Teams Ultimate Edition front suspension bolts**
  2014 · NHTSA 14V539000
- ☐ **TRD brake kit outer brake tube**
  2007–2012 (accessory) · NHTSA 12E046000
- ☐ **Toyota auxiliary driving lamps too bright**
  2007–2013 (accessory) · NHTSA 13V163000
- ☐ **TPMS not recalibrated after accessory wheels**
  2008–2011 · NHTSA 11V148000
- ☐ **Denso low-pressure fuel pump**
  2014 (some) · NHTSA 20V012000

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **VIN and plant**
  US FJs start with JT and were built by Hino at Hamura, Japan. The 10th character is the model year (7 = 2007, A = 2010, E = 2014). 4×4s are GSJ15 and 4×2s GSJ10. On Bring a Trailer, 2007 VINs begin JTEBU11F and 2010–2014 VINs begin JTEBU4BF.
- ☐ **Manual or automatic 4WD**
  Manual trucks have full-time 4WD with a center-differential lock and no 2WD position. Automatic 4×4s have a part-time transfer case with 2H, and automatics were also sold as 4×2s with no transfer-case lever.
- ☐ **Locker and A-TRAC**
  Look for the rear-locker and A-TRAC switches on the dash. The locker was standard with the manual and optional with the automatic (2014 spec), so don't assume every automatic has one.
- ☐ **Trail Teams editions**
  Trail Teams trucks are monotone in that year's color, with blacked-out mirrors, handles and bumper caps, Trail Teams badges and TRD wheels. The 2014 Ultimate Edition is Heritage Blue with a white grille surround and a 'One of 2500' dash plaque. Badges are easy to copy, so ask for the window sticker.
- ☐ **TRD Special Edition**
  The 2007 TRD Special Edition is Black Diamond with a black roof (other FJs have a white roof), with TRD Bilsteins, rock rails, a cat-back exhaust and gunmetal TRD wheels; 3,200 were built.

☐ **Engine generation**
2007–2009 trucks have the single VVT-i engine (239 hp, premium fuel); 2010–2014 trucks have dual VVT-i (259–260 hp, regular).

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/land-cruiser/fj-cruiser/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks